minorities in Bangladesh. All this may culminate in a large-scale exodus of minority groups from Bangladesh. Since there are about nine million Hindus in Bangladesh, India has to live with the problem of dealing with influx from Bangladesh.

The external spy agency believed that the implications of an influx of Bangladeshi minorities needed to be analysed. Apart from adding to India's economic burden, such a migration would create Hindu-Muslim tensions in India, particularly in the north-eastern regions of Bengal and Assam, creating a serious law and order problem even to the extent of jeopardising the tenets of secularism. The R&AW said:

Should an exodus begin, any policy of stopping the refugees at the border by the use of force would be impracticable and we would inevitably be faced with the necessity of accepting these refugees not only on humanitarian grounds, but also due to the pressure of public sentiment particularly in West Bengal where the kith and kin of many of these people reside.

C.G. Somiah, joint secretary in the MHA, warned the states sharing borders with Bangladesh that India could not take upon itself the burden of maintaining Bangladesh nationals coming to India unauthorised and it would be necessary for state governments to take every possible step to locate and push back all illegal immigrants from Bangladesh. Somiah knew that the state governments might not have accurate information about unauthorised Bangladesh nationals in their territories and it was therefore necessary to review the existing intelligence set up in the states so an adequate information base could be created to locate and evict illegal immigrants. Therefore, he suggested a census operation in the border areas with special police powers provided to retired police and revenue officials to